

Early one morning when they were to meet, my father was intent on sorting out “Howard” from “Warren.” Still, at one point in the conversation, my father referred to Warren as “Howard.” If Warren noticed, he gave no sign and certainly did not correct my father. This occurred sporadically throughout the 1970s. By the 1980s, my father finally had purged the word “Howard” from any sentence referencing Buffett. He was actually proud when he left “Howard” behind for good. Years later, I asked him if he ever explained this to Warren. He said he hadn’t because it embarrassed him so much.

Their relationship survived because it was built on much stronger stuff. I think one of the kernels of their relationship was their shared philosophy in associating with people of integrity and skill. When Mr. Buffett says in regard to overseeing Berkshire Hathaway managers, “We don’t tell .400 hitters how to swing,” that is almost straight from Phil Fisher’s playbook. Associate with the best, don’t be wrong about that, and then don’t tell them what to do.

Over the years, my father was very impressed with how Mr. Buffett evolved as an investor without compromising any of his core principles. Every decade, Mr. Buffett has done things no one would have predicted from reading about his past, and done them well. Within professional investing, most people learn in craft-like form some particular style of investing and then never change. They buy low price-earnings (P/E) stocks or leading tech names or whatever. They build that craft and then never change, or change only marginally. In contrast, Warren Buffett consistently took new approaches, decade after decade—so that it was impossible to predict what he might do next. You could not have predicted his 1970s franchise orientation from his original strict value bent. You could not have predicted his 1980s consumer products orientation at above-market average P/Es from his previous approaches. His ability to change—and to do it successfully—could be a book unto itself. When most people attempt to evolve as he has, they fail. Mr. Buffett didn’t fail, my father believed, because he never lost sight of who he was. He always remained true to himself.

My father was never physically far for very long from Rudyard Kipling’s famous poem, “If.” In his desk, by his nightstand, in his den—always close.